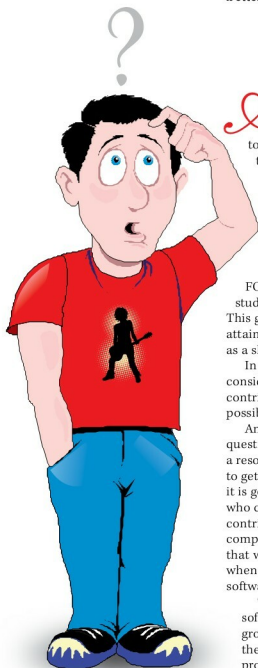


Will FOSS Get Me A Job?

FOSS allows anyone to acquire the skills that lead to becoming a better developer and an improved person.



Any introductory talk on Free and Open Source Software (FOSS) addressed to students will throw up the typical question: "Will FOSS get me a job?" This is generally a follow-up question to "Why should I do this FOSS thing?" A lot of blogs and articles that I read state that in the current economic downturn, FOSS ought to be something students should be looking at. This goes to prove that FOSS has attained mainstream acceptance as a skill worth acquiring.

In short, students should consider participating in and contributing to FOSS as early as possible.

And, as a response to the first question, the answer is generally a resounding NO. FOSS isn't going to get any student a job. However, it is going to equip anyone who chooses to participate or contribute with the required skills, competence, and the recognition that will surely come in handy when building a career around software development.

Training a recently recruited software developer from the ground-up in the basics of the software development process is an expensive and

labour-intensive affair. Yet, lots of companies do so because of the lack of such skills in their freshers. This is one aspect that can be taken care of by gradually acquiring skills in the world of FOSS. The academic curricula that students go through bring them up to speed with the rigour and discipline imposed by the theories. FOSS allows them to immediately implement their knowledge and learn from a collaborative experience.

Let's take the example of students who feel motivated enough to begin by participating in and thereon moving to contributing to FOSS. What skills do they obtain? Plenty.

Since FOSS development is mainly driven over the Internet, the very first skills that get polished are communication skills and the ability to use communication tools like e-mail and IRC (and IMs). Virtual communication puts the responsibility on the sender of the message to be clear, concise and precise. All these are very good qualities to be learnt. Additionally, appreciation of the cultural nuances of interaction, the social norms, etc, make a new contributor a much more well rounded personality in addition to enhancing developer skills.

Moving on, any FOSS project